Beyond the presidential trip, a congressional delegation also visited in January, led by Senate Majority Leader Robert Byrd (D-WV). The Carter trip further led to plans for Desai and all three Indian service chiefs to visit the US in 1978, as well as an agreement to hold annual deputy secretary of state–level talks.[147] In his one-year report card for Carter, among the "pluses," Brzezinski identified relations with India that had "improved markedly."

The national security adviser listed the administration's "seeming disinterest in the Far East" as one of the minuses. He felt that the Sino-US relationship could be "a major stabilizing factor in the global power balance," but the administration had failed to "exploit the Chinese end of the US-Soviet-Chinese triangle." Brzezinski suggested that, around the time of the Strategic Arms Limitation Talks with the Soviets that spring, he could visit China.[148] Carter was on board with eventual normalization but emphasized it would have to be "while protecting Taiwan/US critical relationships."[149] A month later, Brzezinski lamented that Chinese rigidity and—in perhaps a dig at Vance—"excessive [US] sensitivity to the Soviets" in pursuit of détente had caused Washington to "slight" the China connection. He recommended consultations with Beijing at least on global issues, which could send a signal to Moscow. Concerned about political sensitivities, Carter wanted to wait until the Senate ratified the Panama Canal treaties later that spring.[150]

Meanwhile, Washington followed the state of Sino-Indian relations since they affected US priorities. Vajpayee had publicly indicated in October 1977 that India was trying to normalize relations with China.[151] The two countries had taken "helpful" steps, according to Thornton, but problems persisted.[152] India, on its part, continued to have security concerns about China. From the Carter administration's perspective, this Indian threat perception was a key reason for continued Soviet influence in India. It also shaped Delhi's hesitation about other American priorities. India would not accept the idea of complete demilitarization of the Indian Ocean—as opposed to demilitarization by external powers—or of declaring a nuclear-free zone in the region as long as Beijing was not a party to such agreements.[153] India's China concern also affected its stance on Carter's efforts to strengthen the nuclear nonproliferation regime. Delhi was